

Newsletter

Tumaini Sickle Cell Organization



INSIDE, WE ALSO TALK ABOUT:

- The Burden of SCD and Malaria in Kisumu and Kenya
- Impact on Children and Pregnant Mothers
- Human Stories: Voices of Resilience
- Our Work at Tumaini Sickle Cell Organization

Join the Fight Against Sickle Cell Disease and Malaria

What is Sickle Cell Disease (SCD)?

Sickle Cell Disease is a genetic blood disorder caused by a mutation in the β -globin gene, leading to the production of abnormal hemoglobin S. This causes red blood cells to assume a sickle shape, leading to blockages in blood vessels, chronic pain, anemia, and organ damage.

In Kenya, SCD affects an estimated 300,000 individuals, with high prevalence in malaria-endemic regions like Kisumu County. (kenyanedition.com)



The Burden of SCD and Malaria in Kisumu and Kenya

Kisumu County, located in the malaria endemic region of Western Kenya, faces a dual burden of SCD and malaria. The co-morbidity between SCD and *Plasmodium falciparum* malaria exacerbates complications, especially in children, and pregnant mothers.

Impact on Children and Pregnant Mothers

Children with SCD are particularly vulnerable. Without early diagnosis and supportive care, mortality rates are high. The Ministry of Health's guidelines emphasize infant screening and early intervention to reduce morbidity. Pregnant mothers face increased risks of miscarriage, preterm birth, and complications during delivery.

“Co-infection of malaria and SCD, especially among children, show that children with SCD have a 2- to 3-fold increased risk of severe malaria episodes compared to children without SCD, hence the need for integrated management and control strategies.”

Continuation...

Key Statistics:

- SCD prevalence is highest in Nyanza, Western, and Coastal regions. ([The Standard](#))
- Children with SCD in Kisumu suffer more frequent malaria-related complications. ([BMC Infectious Diseases](#))
- Most children with SCD die before age two due to infection and anemia if not diagnosed early. ([africasicklecell.org](#) [The Lancet](#))



“The CEO of TSCO addressing delegates”

Human Stories: Voices of Resilience

Noela Glory's Story.

A teenage warrior from Kisumu, shared her journey during the 2025 Sickie Cell Awareness Walk. Despite frequent hospital visits and pain crises, she continues to advocate for public screening of the general public especially the premarital age, genetic counseling to those found to be trait as a means of strengthening primary prevention measures, mental health support and community education.

Noela encourages fellow warriors to embrace multidisciplinary approach in management of SCD that comprises proper nutrition, adherence to daily medications, and administration of infection prevention vaccines, adequate hydration, moderate exercise and mental wellness. She further appeals to the community and families to respond positively to warriors plight and eliminate stigmatization. She however acknowledges the scarcity of resources that are needed to effectively manage and control the increasing burden of SCD and makes a heartfelt appeal to the government, sponsors and good-willing stakeholders to support genotype screening for SCD in the region.



“Noela encourages fellow warriors to embrace multidisciplinary approach in management of SCD”



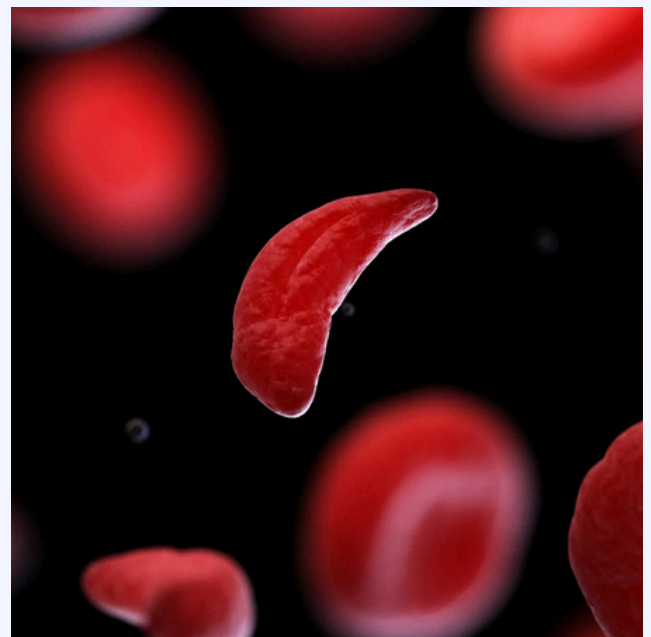
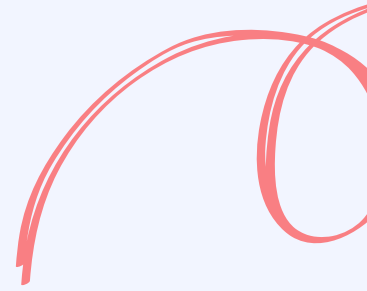
Transmission and Genetic Data

SCD is inherited when both parents carry the sickle cell trait. In Kisumu, intermarriage within high-risk communities contributes to increased transmission rates. (*The Standard*).

Genetic screening and counseling are vital to reduce new cases. According to the Ministry of Health, about 2-3% of newborns in regions with high SCD prevalence are born with the disease, indicating a high carrier rate within communities.

Malaria transmission in Kisumu county, remains high due to its proximity to Lake Victoria and favorable climatic conditions for mosquito breeding. As of 2022, the most recent available data indicates that malaria transmission remains a significant health challenge in the region. (*Kenya Malaria Indicator Survey*) (KMIS) 2019, Kisumu continued to record high malaria prevalence rates particularly among children under 5 years old. The survey reports a prevalence rate of approximately 27% in Kisumu County, reflecting ongoing high transmission rate.

Additionally, (WHO's *World Malaria Report 2022*) highlights that regeons near Lake Victoria are among the most affected in Kenya, with high parasite prevalence and ongoing transmission despite control efforts.



Our Stories:

Another parent from our support group at Jaramogi Oginga Odinga Teaching and Referral Hospital (JOOTRH) recounted how early screening saved her child's life. "We didn't know what was wrong until Tumaini Sickle Cell Organization helped us get tested. Now, my son is thriving," she said County Government of Kisumu.

Our Work at Tumaini Sickle Cell Organization

Tumaini Sickle Cell Organization (TSCO) is dedicated to raising awareness, supporting affected families, and improving treatments related to SCD and malaria.

TSCO operates across four pillars:

1. Patient Support Services

- Formation of age-specific support groups in partnership with JOOTRH County Government of Kisumu
- We provide testing and counseling services to help families understand and manage SCD
- We support children and pregnant women living with SCD, sharing inspiring stories such as that of Noela Glory, a young girl whose health improved through our nutritional support and medical care, enabling her to attend school regularly.
- We regularly carry out blood donation drives to ensure continuous supply of the commodity to support mothers during birth and SCD patients in need of blood transfusion
- Quarterly medical camps

2. Research & Innovation

- Collaboration with universities and health workers to research on SCD-malaria interactions in Kisumu.
- Promotion of genetic screening and data collection for policy planning

3. Community Outreach, Education & Awareness

- Our community outreach educates people on prevention and early detection
- School-based education and caregiver conferences are among our ongoing activities
- Annual Sickle Cell Awareness Walks/runs and Football Fundraisers
[Find Local Businesses](#)

4. Policy & Advocacy

- Collaboration with county health officials to push for universal newborn screening and incorporation of psychosocial support within public health facilities
- Collaboration with government ministries to mainstream SCD and malaria prevention into national health agendas
- Participation in national forums for SCD policy development
- We also advocate for integrated programs addressing both SCD and malaria, which often co-occur in affected regions



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Call to Action.

Addressing SCD and malaria requires collective effort. We call on policymakers, healthcare providers, communities, and donors to support initiatives that promote awareness, early diagnosis, and comprehensive care. By working together, we can reduce the burden of these diseases, save lives, and build healthier futures for children and mothers affected by SCD and malaria.

Every day, children and families in Kisumu County face the harsh realities of sickle cell disease and malaria. The question we are asking is “What can we do to change the story?”

Here's how you can help:

Get screened: Know your sickle cell status and encourage others to do the same. Support early diagnosis: Advocate for universal newborn screening in Kisumu and across Kenya.

Raise your voice: Join our awareness walks, community forums, and social media campaigns.

Donate or fundraise: Help us provide life-saving medication, nutritional support, screening and counseling services.

Partner with us: Whether you're a health worker, policymaker, teacher, or parent, your role matters.

Visit tumainisicklecell.org or follow us on [Facebook](#) to get involved today!

References:

MINISTRY OF HEALTH Policy on Infant Screening

tumainisicklecell.org Tumaini Sickle Cell Organization Website

Find Local Businesses Tumaini Facebook Highlights

County Government of Kisumu Kisumu County Support Groups



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